Portfolio on Communication

Fair and Lovely - Ad Rework

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Reworking a Cluttered Advertisement

Orginal

New-Improved

1	Original (problematic)	Reworked (ethical)
2	4 faces getting progressively lighter	1 face — single, consistent warm brown skin tone
3	"7 Days Challenge" — implies skin tone as a goal	"7-day moisture formula" — the goal is hydration
4	"Guaranteed Results" — false, unsubstantiated claim	"Real ingredients. Honest care. Nothing more." — factual
5	Visual metric = shade lightness	Visual metric = healthy, radiant skin
6	Product sold as identity transformation	Product sold as skincare routine
7	Pink-to-white fade (coded to mean lighter = better)	Warm terracotta palette — celebrates warm tones

Errors Identified :

1. **Colorism as a premise**
   The ads treat darker skin as a problem to be fixed, embedding the message that lighter skin equals greater worth — a racist premise that reinforces existing social prejudice.

2. **Competence tied to appearance**
   Success at work is shown as a consequence of skin tone, not skill. This is factually false, ethically harmful, and violates the dignity of every working woman.

3. **Son preference normalized**
   The father's line — "If only I had a son" — frames a daughter's dark skin as a double burden, normalizing son preference and gender discrimination together.

4. **False product claim**
   The before/after shade transformation shown is medically unsubstantiated. The Advertising Standards Council of India (ASCI) later banned ads depicting skin tone changes as proof of success.

5. **Shallow rebranding (Glow & Lovely, 2020)**
   When HUL rebranded in 2020 under public pressure, it only removed the shade card — the core message and visual language remained identical, treating consumers as uncritical.

Improved Version (Right Side) :

1. Inclusive Visual Representation

The original shows four women with progressively lighter skin — directly implying fairer = better. The redesign uses a single illustrated character with darker skin, presented confidently and positively. It doesn't rank skin tones.

2. Empowering Headline

"your skin. your story." shifts the message from transformation to acceptance. It speaks to the consumer instead of telling them what they should look like.

3. Honest, Specific Claims

Instead of vague "Guaranteed Results", the redesign lists actual ingredients — Niacinamide, Vitamin B3, SPF 15, Dermatologist tested. This builds credibility through transparency.

4. Respectful Tagline

"Real ingredients. Honest care. Nothing more." directly counters the manipulative promise of the original. No false urgency, no impossible guarantees.

5. Cleaner Visual Hierarchy

The right side has clear flow — headline → product → benefits → tagline. The original is chaotic with no clear reading path.

6. Ethical Messaging

The original ad communicates that your natural skin tone is a problem to fix. The redesign communicates that your skin deserves care, not correction — a fundamentally different communication philosophy.

Reflection:

The purpose of this entry is to critically examine how advertising communicates values — and how irresponsibly constructed messaging can normalise discrimination. The Fair & Lovely campaign is a case study in how visual and verbal communication can weaponise insecurity. By identifying its errors and producing a reworked script, this entry demonstrates that ethical communication is not just about clarity, but about what is left unsaid and un-shown.

The target audience for this portfolio entry is fellow students and educators in communication studies, as well as anyone who consumes or creates media. The reworked ad targets the same consumer demographic — Indian women aged 18–35 — but communicates product value without exploiting social anxiety around skin colour.

This entry connects directly to the theme of communication through media. It explores how advertisements function as powerful communicative acts — shaping cultural beliefs, self-image, and social norms. The rework demonstrates that the same product can be communicated honestly, and that responsible media communication is both possible and necessary.

AI Usage Disclosure :

AI tools used: Yes — Claude (Anthropic) was used in the creation of this entry.

Parts involving AI: Research synthesis of campaign history and criticism; structuring of the error analysis; drafting of the reworked ad script;

Nature of use: Idea organisation, research structuring, and writing assistance. All critical judgments, the choice of campaign, and the creative direction of the rework reflect the student's own thinking and academic intent.